

THE LAST INJECTION

Chapter One

The Man Who Came After Midnight

At 11:47 p.m., Dr. Joseph Mathew heard someone knocking on his front door.

Three knocks.

Slow.

Measured.

He looked at the clock again.

11:47.

His wife was supposed to be back by midnight, but she had called twenty minutes earlier to say she would be late. Her mother's blood pressure had suddenly gone up, and she had gone to the pharmacy.

Joseph was alone.

He was not frightened.

Not yet.

He walked towards the door.

Another three knocks.

This time, harder.

"Who's there?"

No answer.

Joseph looked through the small glass panel beside the door.

The porch was empty.

Rain fell steadily over the driveway. The yellow light above the entrance flickered every few seconds, making the darkness beyond the gate appear and disappear.

He unlocked the door.

Before opening it, he stopped.

Something felt wrong.

He looked at his phone.

No missed calls.

He opened the door slightly.

A man stood outside.

Mid-thirties.

Wet hair.

Dark shirt.

No umbrella.

Joseph stared at him.

For several seconds, neither of them spoke.

Then Joseph's face changed.

He knew him.

"How did you get here?"

The man didn't answer.

Joseph slowly stepped backwards.

"Listen..."

The man entered the house.

Joseph looked towards the road.

There was nobody there.

"Why are you here?"

The man closed the door behind him.

Joseph swallowed.

"I told you everything I knew."

The man looked at him.

"No."

His voice was quiet.

"You told me everything you wanted me to know."

Joseph's breathing became heavier.

"Please."

The man took one step forward.

Joseph raised his hands.

"I had nothing to do with what happened to your daughter."

For the first time, something changed in the man's expression.

Not anger.

Something worse.

Pain.

"You signed the form."

Joseph stared at him.

"I didn't know—"

"You knew."

"I didn't know she was going to—"

"You knew."

Joseph backed away until his legs touched the sofa.

"Listen to me. I was only the doctor. I didn't make those decisions."

The man reached into his pocket.

Joseph's eyes dropped towards his hand.

There was no knife.

No gun.

Only a small medical syringe.

Joseph's face went pale.

"No..."

The man stepped closer.

"Do you remember her?"

Joseph said nothing.

"She was eight."

The syringe appeared between them.

"She was afraid of needles."

Joseph's eyes filled with tears.

"Please."

The man looked at him for a long moment.

Then he said:

"She was afraid of dying too."

The lights went out.

At 6:18 the next morning, Joseph Mathew's wife returned home.

She found the front door unlocked.

The television was still on.

A cup of tea sat untouched on the dining table.

Her husband was lying on the living-room floor.

She screamed.

The neighbors came running.

The police arrived seventeen minutes later.

There was no blood.

No broken furniture.

No sign of a struggle.

No weapon.

Nothing had been stolen.

Detective Arun Das, the first officer at the scene, looked at the body and frowned.

"Heart attack?"

The medical examiner shook his head.

"Maybe."

"Maybe?"

"I need to examine him."

Arun looked around the room.

"Any medication?"

"Nothing unusual," the wife said.

"Did he have enemies?"

She stared at him.

"He was a doctor."

Arun sighed.

"That's not an answer."

She wiped her tears.

"Everyone loved him."

Arun looked at the dead man.

People who were loved did not usually die alone on living-room floors with their front doors unlocked.

But he had seen stranger things.

He was about to leave when the medical examiner called him.

"Inspector."

Arun turned.

The examiner pointed towards Joseph's left arm.

"Look here."

There was a tiny red mark just below the elbow.

Almost invisible.

"What is that?"

"I don't know yet."

Arun leaned closer.

"A needle mark?"

"Looks like one."

"Injection?"

"Possibly."

Arun straightened.

"Poison?"

The examiner shook his head.

"Don't know."

He looked at the body again.

"That's the problem."

By 8:30 a.m., the death had become a news story.

By noon, it had become a police case.

By evening, the state police headquarters had decided to send someone from outside the district.

Someone experienced.

Someone who had handled difficult investigations before.

Someone who was supposed to retire in less than six months.

At 9:10 the next morning, a grey Ambassador entered the town police station.

A man stepped out.

He was fifty-five.

His hair was mostly grey.

His shirt was slightly loose around his waist.

He walked with a faint limp.

He carried no dramatic expression, no sunglasses, no sense of urgency.

He looked like a man who had come to finish paperwork before retirement.

The station inspector came out to greet him.

"Sir."

The older officer nodded.

"Where is the body?"

"At the medical college."

"And the crime scene?"

"Sealed."

"Good."

The inspector hesitated.

"Sir, headquarters said you would take charge of the investigation."

The older man looked at him.

"Did headquarters say how many murders we have?"

"One confirmed."

"And?"

"We're waiting for the toxicology report."

The older officer started walking inside.

"Then we don't have a murder case yet."

The inspector followed him.

"But the needle mark—"

"A needle mark doesn't make a murder."

He stopped at the doorway.

"Evidence does."

The inspector nodded.

"What should I call you, sir?"

The older man looked at him.

"Aravind Menon."

Then he walked inside.

Nobody noticed the small photograph sticking out from his wallet.

A little girl.

Seven years old.

Missing one front tooth.

Smiling at the camera.

Her name was Maya.

And six months before Aravind Menon was supposed to retire from the police force, he was going to discover that the case he had been sent to investigate had something to do with the one thing in the world he could not afford to lose.